CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

CARPENTER IN THE AI ERA

The oldest trade on Earth still can't be outsourced to a server. Framing, finish work, built-ins — somebody's hands build all of it.

★ TL;DR — Median around $75K for skilled carpenters, enterable in 1–6 months as a helper with no license required in most places. The catch: your pay follows your skill and your portfolio, not a credential — beginners start low and the ceiling belongs to finish work and self-employment. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

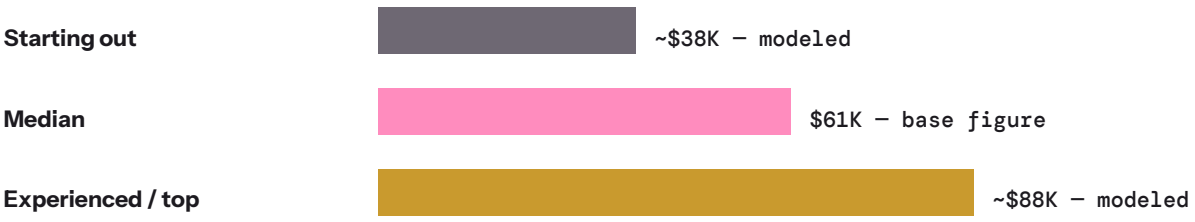
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$61K · TRAINING 2-4 years · AI RISK LOW

- Works because: construction and remodeling never stop, and good carpenters — especially finish carpenters — are chronically scarce.
- Bites because: no license gate means no gate at all — anyone with a saw competes with you, so craftsmanship is the only moat.
- AI angle: minimal. Software lays out cuts and estimates materials; wood still gets measured, cut and fitted by humans on imperfect sites.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Carpenter is a ~$61K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A CARPENTER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Frame walls, floors and roofs; hang doors and windows; install trim, cabinets and built-ins
- ✓ Read plans and layouts, measure twice, and make real-world lumber fit real-world (never square) spaces
- ✓ Build decks, stairs, pergolas and repairs from rot repair to full remodels
- ✓ Run the saw kit: table saw, miter saw, routers, nailers — and keep them tuned and safe

Think: a sculptor whose medium is houses — rough framing is the quarry work, finish carpentry is the gallery work, and the pay knows the difference.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Design software, CNC shops for cabinet parts, and laser measuring. Even prefab components still need humans to fit them into buildings that are never perfectly square.	Fit and judgment: scribing a cabinet to a wavy wall, matching century-old trim, deciding what can be saved. Craft pride is visible in every joint — clients can see the difference even when they can't name it.

⚠ **Entry pay for green helpers is genuinely low, and there's no exam that magically raises it — your raise is your reputation and your photo portfolio. Protect your body early: backs and knees are the career's tax.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ You leave every job with something built that wasn't there in the morning ✓ Work everywhere: new builds, remodels, furniture, film sets, boats ✓ A straight road to your own crew and your own name on the van	✗ Weather, dust, splinters and heavy sheets of plywood ✗ Income swings with construction cycles and seasons ✗ Precision under time pressure, with expensive materials, daily

Good fit? You think in three dimensions, measure carefully, and take visible pride in fit and finish. Math doesn't scare you; sawdust doesn't either.
Bad fit? You want a credential to hide behind, or you hate physical work and early starts. Neither survives a framing crew.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — HELPER ON A CREW	DOOR B — UNION / PRE-APPRENTICESHIP

Get hired as a carpenter's helper by a framing, remodeling or finish crew. You'll carry, cut and clean first, then earn layout and install work. In 1–6 months you'll know if the trade fits — and you'll be paid to find out, with the real climb measured in skills over the following years.	Carpenters' union apprenticeships and pre-apprenticeship programs add structured training — commercial framing, concrete forms, scaffolding — with scheduled raises. Slower to enter, steadier in commercial markets.

Smart move: Aim up the value ladder deliberately: framing → trim and doors → cabinets and built-ins. Each step pays better and wrecks your body less. Photograph everything you finish; your portfolio is your license.

Where you land after: Helper → carpenter → finish carpenter / lead → foreman, or your own remodeling and custom-build business.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
GET ON	LEARN TO	READ PLANS,	CLIMB TOWARD	PRICE YOUR	LEAD OR

STEP 1 — Get on a crew

FREE · TODAY

- Apply to remodeling companies, framing crews and general contractors hiring helpers — show up in person where that's the local custom.
- Basic kit: tape, speed square, hammer, tool belt, boots. Accuracy beats expensive tools.

STEP 2 — Learn to measure and cut true

MONTHS 1-6

- Master the tape, the square and the saw: straight cuts, true miters, safe habits.
- Learn lumber: species, grades, moisture, and why boards move after you install them.

STEP 3 — Read plans, do layout

ONGOING

- Blueprint reading turns helpers into carpenters: walls, openings, stairs, roof geometry.
- Volunteer for layout work with the lead — it's the thinking layer of the trade.

STEP 4 — Climb toward finish work

YEAR 1+

- Trim, doors, cabinets and built-ins: tighter tolerances, better pay, cleaner work.
- Build a photo portfolio of every finished piece — this is your pricing power.

STEP 5 — Price your own side work

WEEKENDS

- Small jobs for your own clients: decks, shelves, repairs. Learn estimating by doing it.
- Keep it legal: no license is generally required for carpentry itself, but permits and contractor rules apply to bigger jobs — check locally.

STEP 6 — Lead or launch

YEAR 2+

- Run a crew as lead carpenter/foreman, or formalize your own business with insurance and a specialty.
- Specialties that pay: custom built-ins, high-end trim, historic restoration.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- Today: list five local crews hiring helpers; get your basic hand tools together.
- Days 1–30: on a crew, carrying and cutting; tape-and-square accuracy drills are your homework.
- Days 31–60: first layout tasks under the lead; start your photo portfolio.
- Days 61–90: aim for your first trim or install work; ask what separates their best carpenter from the rest.
- Day 90: employed, measurably more skilled, with photos to prove it — that's this trade's currency.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **MEASURE TWICE. GET PAID ONCE.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.